

Unified Payments Interface (UPI) Safety Guidelines & PIN Security

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Official Source: <https://www.npci.org.in/what-we-do/upi/upi-safety-tips>

Official Advisory: NPCI Public Advisory: Safe UPI Transactions and QR Code Hygiene

Core Principle: When is UPI PIN Needed?

A UPI PIN is strictly and exclusively required to SEND or DEBIT money from your bank account. A UPI PIN is NEVER required to RECEIVE money, collect cash, accept refunds, or claim cashback. If anyone asks you to enter your UPI PIN, approve a collect request, or scan a QR code to receive funds, it is an outright cyber fraud attempt. Do not enter your PIN under any circumstances.

QR Code Mechanism & Fraud Traps

A Quick Response (QR) code in UPI is a payment request mechanism. Scanning a QR code authorizes a DEBIT from your account. Scammers frequently send QR codes over WhatsApp, Telegram, or OLX claiming 'Scan this QR code to receive your payment/advance/cashback'. Scanning this QR code and entering your PIN will instantly deduct money from your account, transferring it to the fraudster.

UPI Collect Request Manipulation

Fraudsters exploit the 'Collect Request' feature of UPI apps. They initiate a collect request with names like 'Cashback_Aproved_5000' or 'Refund_Department'. The victim receives a prompt on PhonePe, Google Pay, or Paytm asking for UPI PIN. Entering the PIN transfers the requested amount to the attacker.

Emergency Resolution via UPI HELP

If an unauthorized or disputed transaction occurs, immediately open your UPI application, go to transaction history, select the disputed transaction, and click 'UPI HELP' or 'Raise Complaint'. You can also escalate directly through NPCI's dispute resolution mechanism on npci.org.in and dial the national cyber helpline 1930.

Citizen Action Checklist & Red Flags

- **Verify Sender Identity:** Always check official website addresses and header IDs (e.g., VM-SBI, AX-HDFC). Scammers use fake sender masks.
- **Never Share Authentication Secrets:** Passwords, OTPs, UPI PINs, and debit card CVVs are strictly confidential. Bank staff will NEVER ask for them.
- **Independent Verification:** If you receive a threat or alert about an account freeze, call the official bank branch number found on your physical card or bank statement.
- **Immediate Reporting:** Report cyber financial fraud within the Golden Hour by calling 1930 or visiting cybercrime.gov.in.

Frequently Asked Questions (Regulatory Clarifications)

Q1: Can money be deposited into my bank account by entering my UPI PIN?

A: No. A UPI PIN is solely an authorization to debit funds from your linked bank account. Receiving funds requires NO authentication or PIN entry.

Q2: What is the first action to take if money is fraudulently deducted?

A: Dial 1930 immediately to register the complaint on the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) CFCFRMS portal so that the beneficiary account can be frozen before funds are withdrawn.

Q3: What should I do if an unknown caller threatens me with a police arrest over video call?

A: Disconnect immediately. Indian police and law enforcement agencies never issue summons, conduct investigations, or place citizens under 'Digital Arrest' via video calls.

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